KINGKILLER CHRONICLE TEXT ADVENTURE
Project Planning Document — v1.0

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1. PROJECT VISION

What kind of game is this?

This is a simulation-first, narrative-rich, canon-faithful interactive fiction experience. Not a combat system with story wrapping. Not a choose-your-own-adventure. Not a dungeon crawler with Rothfuss aesthetics bolted on.

It is a game where inhabiting the world is the point. Where going to the Eolian and listening to a lute player for an evening is a complete and meaningful turn. Where running out of money has weight. Where a reputation damaged by one ill-chosen sentence at the wrong table follows the player for weeks. Where magic is not a power fantasy but a discipline with costs, failure states, and social consequences.

The primary experience is: being someone specific, somewhere specific, at a specific moment in a living, socially textured world.

What does "faithful to Rothfuss" mean in practice?

It means several things operating simultaneously:

Tonal faithfulness. The prose should feel intelligent, quiet, and precise. It earns its moments of beauty by surrounding them with grit and hunger and boredom and cold. It does not perform lyrical beauty constantly. The world feels worn, real, and old.

Structural faithfulness. Rothfuss builds through accumulation of small true detail, not through dramatic peaks. The game must allow and reward that pace. A scene of Kvothe counting coins under lamplight before deciding whether to eat or save for tuition should feel as meaningful as a scene with Elodin.

Mystery faithfulness. The books are fundamentally about what we don't know. The Chandrian, the Amyr, the Lackless family, the Doors of Stone, the nature of Denna's patron — these are not puzzles to be solved by a clever player. They are the permanent horizon. The game must preserve that. Satisfying the player's curiosity cheaply would be a betrayal of what makes this world work.

Material faithfulness. Money is specific in these books. Talents, jots, and drabs. Tuitions are specific. The cost of a room at Anker's is specific. The smell of the Medica, the sound of sympathy links failing, the texture of the Underthing — these details exist, and they must be honoured.

What would make it feel unlike a generic fantasy text RPG?

These five things, above all:

1. Consequences are social, not just physical. You don't just take damage — you lose standing, lose access, lose trust.
2. Magic is not a power system. Sympathy costs alar focus and body heat. Naming is rare and dangerous and not reliably available. There is no mana bar.
3. The world does not revolve around the player. NPCs have lives. Events happen without the player. The University has politics the player only partially observes.
4. Slowness is rewarded. Paying attention to a rumour. Learning a song. Watching how someone moves through a room. These are valid and valuable actions.
5. Uncertainty is not a failure state. Not knowing something is the correct condition. The game models partial information, rumour, hearsay, and deliberate ambiguity as features, not bugs.

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2. DESIGN PILLARS

Pillar 1: Canon First
Every design decision defers to published text. If something isn't in the books, it doesn't get invented and presented as fact. If it's ambiguous in canon, it remains ambiguous in game. The game is a lens onto the books, not an expansion of them.

Pillar 2: Mystery Preserved
The great unresolved questions of the series — the Chandrian's true nature, the Amyr's purpose, Denna's patron, the Doors of Stone — must never be answered by the game. They must feel heavier and more present the deeper the player goes, not lighter.

Pillar 3: Social and Material Realism
Class, gender, race, rank, money, hunger, shelter, debt, favours, and reputation must all function as real variables. The world is not fair, and the game should not pretend it is.

Pillar 4: Location Density and Geographic Coherence
Every named location must feel like it has rooms, thresholds, smells, sounds, and regular inhabitants. Movement between places takes real time with real costs. You cannot teleport. You cannot casually enter restricted spaces.

Pillar 5: Character Authenticity
Every canon character must speak, think, and behave like themselves. They cannot be flattened into quest-givers or plot tools. Elodin is not a quirky wizard NPC. Denna is not a romance reward. Kote is not a friendly barkeep.

Pillar 6: Magic as Discipline, Not Power Fantasy
Sympathy requires training, focus, materials, and carries physical cost. Naming is rarer, less reliable, and more dangerous still. No spell lists. No cooldowns. No guaranteed outcomes. Magic is hard and consequential.

Pillar 7: Timeline Precision

Each era is distinct. NPCs who are dead in one era are alive in another. Knowledge available in one era is not available in another. The player's character knows only what their character would know at that point in time. No meta-knowledge bleeds across eras.

Pillar 8: Consequences That Accumulate
Actions have effects that persist. A lie told to a master in Week 3 affects how that master treats the player in Week 8. A debt unpaid changes social access. A performance praised at the Eolian opens doors. Nothing is reset.

Pillar 9: Slow Play Rewarded
Observation, listening, patience, and restraint should be mechanically and narratively meaningful. The game should resist the impulse to always push the player toward action.

Pillar 10: Prose That Is Original, Evocative, and Tonally True

The narration must not copy Rothfuss. It must feel compatible with him. Clear, careful, slightly lyrical, never breathless. Rooted in material detail. Emotionally intelligent without being sentimental.

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3. SCOPE DEFINITION

Must Have (Core — no game without these)
- At least one fully realised era with multiple coherent, navigable locations
- Canon-faithful playable characters with correct voice and behaviour
- Sympathy magic modelled with cost, skill, and consequence
- A working reputation/social standing system
- Money and basic material needs (lodging, food, tuition where applicable)
- Correct canon NPCs behaving correctly in the right eras
- Conversation that rewards careful attention
- Persistent world state that tracks choices and consequences
- Preserved mystery — unresolved lore stays unresolved
- Tone-correct narration

Should Have (Important — game is weaker without these)
- Multiple eras available (at minimum: University and Waystone frame)
- Music/performance system
- The Underthing (accessible carefully)
- Sygaldry and artificing in the Fishery
- Academic rank and tuition system at the University
- Multiple playable canon characters
- Travel between Imre and the University
- Injury and health tracking
- A clue/rumour tracking system for mysteries
- Denna as a properly handled, non-trivial NPC

Could Have (Nice additions for later phases)

- Tarbean era fully realised
- Troupe childhood era
- Felurian's realm (requiring extreme canon discipline)
- Ademre
- The full Chandrian mythos playable around the edges
- Deep Auri gameplay in the Underthing
- Play as Bast or Kote in the frame story
- Political machinations within University faculty

Should Not Have (Keep these out — they break the game)

- Combat as a central mechanic
- A spell list or ability tree for magic
- Quest markers or objective tracking UI language
- Invented lore presented as canon fact
- Resolution of series mysteries
- Modern idiom, tone, or humour
- Procedural generation of locations or NPCs
- Crossover with other fantasy properties
- Fan theory content
- Unnamed generic NPCs as primary social content
- XP, levels, stats expressed as numbers to the player

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4. CANON AND LORE STRATEGY

Sources of Truth (Priority Order)

1. The Name of the Wind (2007) — primary
2. The Wise Man's Fear (2011) — primary
3. The Slow Regard of Silent Things (2014) — primary for Auri, Underthing
4. Rothfuss interviews and confirmed statements — secondary, with caution; subject to revision
5. Nothing else — not wikis, not fan analysis, not Reddit speculation, not Oot's story

Fan wikis can be used as finding aids to locate canonical passages, but must always be verified against the actual text before use. Treat wikis as potentially contaminated with fanon.

Separating Confirmed Fact from Inference

Build a three-tier system for every lore claim:

Tier 1: Direct canon statement. The book says it, unambiguously. ("The tuition was three talents and one jot.")

Tier 2: Strong canonical implication. The text strongly implies something without stating it explicitly. Use this cautiously. Note the implication without asserting certainty.

Tier 3: Reasonable inference. A gap is filled by logic consistent with canon. Always mark this. Never present it as fact in the game world. Prefer to leave gaps as gaps.

Unknown / unresolved. If it falls outside these tiers, it remains unknown in-game. The game honours "we don't know" as a valid state.

Preventing Fanon Contamination

- All NPCs, locations, and facts should be traceable to a specific book passage before inclusion
- Keep a running citation document — every game element links to its canon source
- Periodically run a "canon audit" pass during development: ask "where in the text does this come from?"
- Common fanon to be actively excluded: specific Chandrian identities and backstories as settled fact, patron = specific character as settled fact, resolution of Kvothe's name meaning, specific content from unpublished Book 3

Handling Unknown or Unresolved Lore

The game handles it one of two ways:

1. In-world uncertainty. Characters in the game have incomplete, contradictory, or mythologised information, just as they do in the books. This is the preferred approach — the in-world characters also don't know.

2. Graceful silence. The game simply doesn't go there. A door stays closed. A character deflects. An NPC gives three conflicting rumours. The narrator describes only what can be seen.

The game never says "this is unknown to you" in a way that feels like a wall — it says it through the texture of the world itself.

Tracking System for Canon Elements

Build a Lore Register as a living document with these categories:

Category	Fields
Locations	Name, tier of canon confirmation, description, era(s), relationships to other locations, canon source
Characters	Name, era(s) active, social status, relationships, known capabilities, what is public/private/unknown, canon source
Institutions	Name, function, hierarchy, access rules, relevant eras
Currency	Names, relative values, confirmed prices where canon gives them
Magic Systems	Name, known rules, costs, limitations, tier of canon support
Customs & Sayings	Text, context, source
Timeline Events	Event, era, what it changes, canon source
Relationships	Character A, Character B, nature of relationship, what is known/unknown

| Mysteries | Question, what canon confirms, what is implied, what is unresolved — never resolved |

This document is the single source of truth for the game. All content is checked against it before shipping.

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5. WORLD MODEL

Structural Hierarchy

```
World
└── Regions
    └── Cities / Settlements
        └── Districts / Areas
            └── Buildings / Locations
                └── Rooms / Spaces
                    └── Objects / Details
```

Confirmed Regions and Settlements (Canon-Grounded)

The Commonwealth
- The University (specific campus geography confirmed in text)
- Imre (across the river from the University)
- Tarbean (large port city, specific districts implied)
- Newarre (frame story village, specific named residents)
- Trebon (referenced, visited briefly)

The Four Corners more broadly
- Vintas (Kvothe visits, specific locations confirmed)
- Ademre (Kvothe trains there)
- The Eld (forest, confirmed in travel)
- Felurian's realm (outside normal geography — handle with extreme care)

Location Availability by Era

Location	Troupe Era	Tarbean Era	University Era	Frame Era
Waystone Inn	No	No	No	Yes
Newarre	No	No	No	Yes
University	No	No	Yes	Ruins/changed
Imre / Eolian	No	No	Yes	Unknown
Tarbean	Briefly	Yes	Occasionally	Unknown
Troupe wagons / roads	Yes	No	No	No
Underthing	No	No	Yes	Unknown

| Adenre | No | No | Late-book only | Unknown |

Key University Locations (Canon-Confirmed)
- The Artificery (Fishery)
- The Archives (Tomes, Stacks, Acquisitions, Four-Plate Door)
- The Medica
- The Masters' Hall
- Mains (lecture hall)
- Kilvin's workroom
- Elxa Dal's classroom (sympathy practice)
- The Mews (student housing)
- The Rookery (student housing, lower tier)
- Anker's Inn (student social space, Kvothe works here)
- The Bawdy Nymph / other student taverns
- Elodin's tower (and the roof)
- The Crockery (asylum, off-campus, referenced)

Key Imre Locations (Canon-Confirmed)
- The Eolian (musician's venue, test stage, gallery, tavern floor)
- Devi's room (money-lender, notable location)
- Shops, streets, the river bridge

Travel and Physical Coherence Rules
- Travel between University and Imre: on foot, specific time commitment (confirmed as a reasonable walk, not instant)
- Travel to Tarbean: days, not hours; requires transport, money, reason
- All travel has weather, time, fatigue, and cost as real variables
- Locked locations (Four-Plate Door, restricted Archive stacks, masters' private spaces) remain locked unless canonical events open them
- The Underthing requires the right entry points; Auri's routes are her own

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6. CHARACTER MODEL

Template for Each Canon Character

Each playable and major NPC character needs the following documented before any writing:

Identity: Full name(s), known aliases, physical description from text
Era(s) active: Which time periods they appear in and in what role
Speech style: How they actually talk in the books — vocabulary, sentence rhythm, what they say vs what they withhold
Core temperament: Primary drives, fears, blind spots
Social position: Class, rank, institutional role, how others perceive them
Known capabilities: What they can do, confirmed by canon
Known limitations: What they cannot or will not do
Key relationships: With other canon characters, their nature and limits

What is public: What most people in the world would know about them
What is private: What only some people know
What is unknown: What even the books don't confirm, and must stay uncertain

Critical Character-Specific Notes

Kvothe: Brilliant and aware of it. Impulsive in ways that cost him. Genuinely poor for much of University era. Emotionally damaged about his parents. Proud about his Ruh heritage while also vulnerable about it. Does not have reliable access to naming. His skills are musical, academic, and sympathy — not superheroic.

Kote (frame era Kvothe): Deliberately diminished. Speaks carefully. The skills are there but banked. Bast's concern is real and the weight of it must be present in every scene. He is not a friendly innkeeper. He is a man in controlled retreat from himself.

Denna: Cannot be reduced to a love interest or a mystery box. She is intelligent, self-determining, economically precarious, charming as a survival skill, and genuinely elusive. Her patron is unknown and must stay that way. She is not available as a companion or ally on demand.

Elodin: Not quirky for comic effect. His strangeness has a logic the books gesture at without explaining. He is genuinely dangerous, genuinely perceptive, and his teaching methods make more sense than they appear to. He must never be a dispenser of answers.

Auri: Every interaction requires care. Her speech, her logic, her world, her rules must come from The Slow Regard of Silent Things specifically. She is not eccentric for flavour — she is her own complete thing. She must never be made to explain herself in conventional terms.

Bast: Warm on the surface, ancient and fae and genuinely dangerous underneath. His concern for Kvothe is real and complicated. He is not human. That must be palpable without being constantly announced.

Simmon: The most underrated character in the series for what he represents — genuine human decency, emotional intelligence, and warmth that isn't naive. He must not be comic relief. He sees things clearly and cares genuinely.

Fela, Mola: Both fully competent, distinct people with their own trajectories. Neither is a generic supporting woman. Fela is artistic, observant, socially aware. Mola is sharp, clinically precise, not particularly tolerant of nonsense.

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7. TIMELINE MODEL

The Five Eras

Era 1: The Troupe (Childhood, pre-massacre)

Kvothe is roughly 8–12. Living with the Edema Ruh. Arliden and Laurian alive. Abenthy present briefly. The world is roads, wagons, performances, lessons, music, and the beginning of sympathy learning. This is the most tonally warm era — which makes what follows its destruction matter more.

What's true: Troupe alive, Chandrian unknown, Kvothe has no enemies, University is a dream not a place
What changes: The massacre. Nothing is the same after it.

Era 2: Tarbean (Orphan years, roughly age 11–15)
Kvothe is feral, surviving, watching from below social structures. Deep poverty. Skarpi. The Tehlin church. Learning the city from underneath. This is a dark, slow, survivalist era.

What's true: Parents dead, no skills except music and raw intelligence, no money, no patron, no magic use
What changes: Eventual recovery of will and departure for the University

Era 3: University (Main era — two published books)
Kvothe is admitted at roughly 15, unusually young. This is the richest era for gameplay: academic rank, tuition, sympathy, sygaldry, the Archives, relationships with Simmon/Wilem/Fela/Mola/Elodin/Kilvin/Ambrose, Denna appearances, the Eolian, financial pressure, performing, gradually growing reputation and enemies.

Internal timeline within this era matters: Kvothe's rank advances. Relationships deepen or break. Specific events (the whipping, the sympathy duel, Elodin's class, the Archives ban and reinstatement) are fixed canon events requiring careful handling.

Era 4: Beyond the University (Late-book eras)
Vintas, Ademre, Felurian's realm, the Maer's court. These require additional canon discipline because the locations and cultures are less thoroughly detailed than the University.

Era 5: The Frame (Waystone Inn)
Kote, Bast, Chronicler. Three days. The world is wrong — the Eld is full of things it shouldn't have, roads are unsafe, the war is somewhere nearby. This era is about weight, silence, controlled revelation, and dread.

Era-Specific Rules

The game must track per era:
- Which characters are alive, where, in what role
- What Kvothe/the player character knows
- What institutions exist and in what form
- What social access the player has
- What threats are real and which are not yet real
- What rumours and folklore circulate vs what is confirmed

Cross-era contamination is a critical failure mode. A player should never have access to information their character wouldn't have at that moment.

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8. CORE GAMEPLAY SYSTEMS

8.1 Movement and Exploration

- Locations have exits to adjacent spaces
- Some exits are locked by access (rank, relationship, time of day, physical key)
- Moving through significant locations generates narration of what is seen, heard, smelled
- Visiting a location multiple times should not generate identical narration — the time of day, season, player state, and world state all affect description
- Travel between major locations (University to Tarbean, etc.) is a time-advancing action with consequences, not instant

8.2 Conversation

- Conversation with NPCs is not a menu of options
- The player directs the topic, tone, and approach
- NPCs respond to: what the player knows, what the NPC knows, the player's reputation with them, their own mood and circumstances
- Information is parcelled out realistically — NPCs don't monologue usefully on demand
- Lies are possible, risky, and traceable
- Silence is a valid conversational choice

8.3 Inventory

- Tracked items: clothes, instruments, sympathy tools (wick, candle, linking material, focus aids), notes and books, any meaningful carried objects
- Encumbrance is realistic but not gamey — carrying too much has practical consequences, not a stat penalty
- Some items are deeply significant (the lute, the cloak) and must be treated accordingly

8.4 Money

- Currency: talents, jots, drabs (canonical denominations)
- Prices where canon confirms them should be used; elsewhere, era-consistent estimation
- Tracked as a real variable with consequences
- Regular expenses: lodging, food, tuition, tools, materials, instrument maintenance
- Money pressure should be real, especially in Tarbean and early University eras

8.5 Reputation

- Track reputation along multiple axes, not a single number:
  - Academic standing (University rank: E'lir, Re'lar, El'the)
  - Social reputation at the University (among students, among masters — separately)
  - Performance reputation (Eolian, Anker's)
  - Specific relationships (trust/tension with individual named characters)
  - Ruh identity (openly Edema Ruh or concealed — has consequences either way)
- Reputation changes have lag — word travels at realistic speed
- Bad reputation in one domain doesn't necessarily affect others (a student feared by peers may still be admired at the Eolian)

8.6 Study and Academic Rank
- University era only
- Rank advancement: Arcanum entry → E'lir → Re'lar → El'the
- Each advancement has specific requirements in canon (exams before masters)
- Missing classes, antagonising masters, and academic failures have consequences
- Access to restricted areas (certain Archive stacks, certain labs) is gated by rank

8.7 Music and Performance
- Lute playing is a skill and a world-building element, not a mini-game
- Performance quality is affected by instrument condition, player emotional state, practice, audience
- The Eolian has specific social and reputational stakes
- Music can open social doors, provide income, and matter for specific canon events
- The naming-through-music connection (Kvothe's Alar) must be hinted at carefully, not over-explained

8.8 Magic: Sympathy
- Requires alar (split attention), binding, and physical cost (body heat primarily)
- Materials matter: candles, cord, clay, metal, specifically prepared items
- Skill level affects reliability and efficiency
- Failure states: slips, bleed-through, injury, unconsciousness
- Cannot be used reliably in emotional distress without training to match
- Sygaldry (engraved sympathy) is permanent but requires Fishery access and materials
- Artificing is a craft, not magic — it's skilled labour with magical properties

8.9 Magic: Naming
- Available only in specific states: clarity, exhaustion-break, extreme crisis, deep focus
- Cannot be turned on like a switch
- Early in University era: barely glimpsed, poorly understood
- What Kvothe can name is strictly limited to what canon shows
- The wind is his first real naming — and even that is fragile
- Do not expand naming capabilities beyond what canon supports at any given moment

8.10 Health, Injury, Fatigue
- Injuries persist until treated (Medica access matters)
- Fatigue affects sympathy and attention
- Hunger affects everything
- Sleep deprivation (which Kvothe famously endures) has real cognitive cost
- Cold (thermodynamic sympathy cost) is real — don't use sympathy when already cold or injured without consequence

8.11 Lodging, Food, Weather, and Time
- Time passes in a realistic way: morning, afternoon, evening, night
- Weather is present and affects travel, mood, and available activities
- Lodging is a real daily expense; sleeping rough has safety consequences
- Hunger is tracked; not eating affects performance and magic
- Term calendar at the University: admissions, tuition deadlines, break periods

8.12 Clues, Rumours, and Mystery Tracking

- The game tracks what the player has heard, from whom, and how reliable it seems
- Multiple conflicting rumours about the same subject are possible and intentional
- The game never aggregates this into a "mystery solved" state for unresolved series mysteries
- Player can ask around, investigate, follow leads — but the horizon stays the horizon
- Some clues have in-game payoff; others are simply true to the world

8.13 Consequences and World State

- World state is a persistent record of choices, events, and their effects
- World state updates affect: NPC attitudes, location access, available actions, narration tone
- Some world state changes are slow (reputation shifts, relationship growth)
- Some are immediate (being caught somewhere you shouldn't be)
- The game does not protect the player from consequences but does not manufacture them unfairly

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9. NARRATIVE STRUCTURE

Sandbox vs Guided Balance

The game is simulation-forward with narrative anchors, not a linear story with the illusion of choice.

The simulation layer runs constantly: time passes, NPCs move through their days, tuition is due, the weather changes, rumours circulate. The player can follow any thread or none.

The narrative anchor layer provides: canon-fixed events that will occur regardless of player action (tuition day, the whipping in University era, the massacre in troupe era), and character-driven goals the player naturally develops through play (wanting to learn a particular skill, wanting to find out something, wanting to repair a relationship).

Canon-Fixed Events

Some events in the books are fixed. They happened. In a game set during those eras, they will happen. The question is not whether but how the player experiences them:

- What do they notice?
- What do they attempt to change around the edges?
- What secondary effects follow from how they positioned themselves?
- How do they feel?

The game should not prevent the massacre, should not prevent the whipping, should not prevent Kvothe's expulsion from the Archives. But the player can affect the texture of how those events unfold, what they learn, and what they do immediately after.

Preserving Agency Without Breaking Canon

- Canon fixes major events, not every small moment
- Canon fixes what happens, not how the player feels, responds to secondary details, or navigates the aftermath
- Canon fixes Kvothe's public story — but large stretches of his actual daily life are not detailed
- Between canonical peaks, the game has enormous room for player-driven play

Handling Iconic Book Scenes

Scenes that most readers remember vividly (the lute playing for Felurian, the sympathy duel with Ambrose, the first time Kvothe calls the wind) must be treated with care:

- Do not reproduce the book's prose
- Allow the player to approach the scene from their own angle
- The emotional core of the scene must be intact
- Do not let the player trivially sidestep what the scene demands of the character

Slow Daily Life vs Dramatic Events

Both should feel valid. A turn spent watching Auri leave small gifts in unexpected places should feel as real and meaningful as a turn spent in a sympathy duel. The game should never feel like it's pushing the player toward action.

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10. INFORMATION ARCHITECTURE

Conceptual Schema (Not Final Code — Platform-Agnostic)

Location
```
id
name
era_availability: [list of eras]
description_base
description_variants: {time_of_day, weather, player_state, world_state_flags}
exits: [{direction, target_location_id, access_condition}]
npcs_present: [{npc_id, conditions}]
objects_present: [{object_id, conditions}]
canon_source: [book, chapter/page reference]
tier: [1 = confirmed, 2 = implied, 3 = inferred]
```

Room (sub-location)
```
id
parent_location_id
name
```

```
description_base
description_variants
exits
objects
canon_source
tier
```

Character (NPC)
```
id
name
aliases: [list]
era_availability: [list]
location_default: {era: location_id}
speech_style_notes
temperament_notes
social_status: {era: description}
known_capabilities: [list with canon_source]
known_limitations: [list with canon_source]
relationships: [{npc_id, nature, what_is_public, what_is_private}]
what_is_publicly_known
what_is_privately_known
what_is_unknown_in_canon
dialogue_rules
canon_source
tier
```

Item
```
id
name
description
significance (mundane / significant / canon-critical)
era_availability
location_default
obtainable: bool
conditions_for_obtaining
canon_source
```

Time Period / Era
```
id
name
description
approximate_kvothe_age
```

key_facts_true_in_this_era: [list]
key_facts_not_yet_true: [list]
canon_source
```

Event
```
id
name
era
is_canon_fixed: bool
trigger_condition
description
world_state_changes: [list]
player_agency_notes
canon_source
```

Dialogue Node / Rule
(Prefer rules over nodes for flexibility)
```
npc_id
topic
conditions: {player_reputation_with_npc, player_knowledge_flags, world_state_flags}
response_template
information_revealed
information_withheld
follow_up_options
```

Quest / Lead / Rumour
```
id
type: [quest, lead, rumour]
title
description
source_npc or location
is_canon_resolvable: bool (can this actually be answered in-game?)
resolution_conditions
if unresolvable: behaviour (remains open, deepens, contradicts itself)
related_mystery (for mystery tracking)
```

Player State
```
character_id
era
location_id

```
time_of_day
date_in_term (University era)
inventory: [item_ids]
money: {talents, jots, drabs}
health: {description, injuries}
fatigue_level
hunger_level
academic_rank (University era)
known_sympathy_bindings
known_sygaldry
naming_moments_experienced: [list]
reputation: {
  academic: value,
  student_social: value,
  masters_relations: {master_id: value},
  eolian_standing: value,
  ruh_identity_disclosed: bool,
  individual_relationships: {npc_id: {trust: value, tension: value}}
}
knowledge_flags: [things the player has learned]
promises_made: [list]
debts: [{to: npc_id, amount_or_nature}]
world_state_flags_triggered: [list]
```

World State
```
era
active_events: [event_ids]
completed_events: [event_ids]
npc_states: {npc_id: {location, mood, knowledge_of_player, attitude}}
location_states: {location_id: {access_locked, special_conditions}}
rumour_pool: [active rumours in circulation]
time_elapsed
season_weather
```

Canon Citation / Source Reference
```
element_id
element_type
claim
book: [NotW, WMF, SRST]
chapter_or_page
tier: [1=direct, 2=implied, 3=inferred]
notes
```

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11. CONTENT PIPELINE

What to Build First

1. The Lore Register — before writing a single scene, the canon database must exist. This prevents drift from day one.
2. The World Schema — establish the data structure before populating it.
3. The University campus as the first fully realised location set.
4. 5–7 core NPCs for the University era with complete character documents.
5. The basic systems (movement, conversation, money, reputation) in minimal working form.
6. One complete arc of 10–15 scenes that demonstrates the full system working together.

How to Template Without Writing Badly

Each location gets a Location Design Document before prose is written:

- What is this place for? (Social function, not just physical)
- Who uses it, when, and why?
- What tensions exist here regularly?
- What does it smell like, sound like, feel like in different conditions?
- What is always true of it? What changes?
- What access rules apply?
- How does it connect to adjacent spaces?

Only once this document exists does prose description get written.

Avoid: Writing 100 room descriptions as isolated set pieces. They will feel disconnected and lifeless.

Do instead: Write clusters — the Fishery as a complete environment, not individual rooms. The Archive as a complete environment. Each cluster has internal coherence and external relationship to the rest of the world.

Writing NPCs Consistently

Each NPC gets a Character Voice Document before any dialogue is written:

- Five sample sentences in their voice (drawn from canonical dialogue where possible)
- What they never say (things that would be out of character)
- What topics make them open vs closed
- What they want from interactions
- How they treat the player character depending on standing

All dialogue is reviewed against this document before it ships.

Reviewing for Canon Drift

Periodic canon audit passes:

- Does every location, character fact, and event have a citation?
- Has any character started behaving out of character under gameplay pressure?
- Have any of the series mysteries been edged toward resolution?
- Has any Tier 3 inference started being treated as Tier 1 fact?
- Does the magic system still have meaningful costs and limits?

Run this audit at the end of each content phase.

Testing for "Rothfuss-like" Feel

Without copying prose, the tone test is:

- Does this scene earn its emotional moment through accumulated detail?
- Is there something materially specific here (a price, a smell, a worn object)?
- Does this character's dialogue sound like themselves or like a convenient plot delivery system?
- Is there something unknown or unresolvable in this scene that adds texture?
- Would a person who loved the books feel recognised or feel condescended to?

Have a small group of people who know the books well read each new content cluster before it ships. Their instinctive responses ("this felt off," "this felt right") are more reliable than any checklist.

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12. MVP RECOMMENDATION

Recommended MVP: University Era, Term One

The case for this:

The University is the most thoroughly described location in the books. It has:

- Confirmed geography
- Confirmed NPCs with extensive dialogue examples
- Confirmed social hierarchy and academic systems
- Confirmed magic instruction (sympathy, sygaldry)
- Confirmed daily pressures (tuition, rank, poverty, study)
- The richest secondary cast of any era
- Enough non-magical social content to sustain extended play

It is also the era most readers care most about. An MVP here is immediately recognisable, immediately testable against reader memory, and immediately satisfying if done well.

What the University Term One MVP would contain:
- Core campus locations (Fishery, Archives, Mains, Medica, Mews, Anker's)
- Imre and the Eolian as reachable locations
- 6 core NPCs: Simmon, Wilem, Elodin, Kilvin, Ambrose, Denna (appearing occasionally)

- Basic sympathy system
- Academic rank system (E'lir starting level)
- Money and tuition pressure
- Reputation with masters and students separately
- Music/performance at Anker's and the Eolian
- 3–4 canon-anchored events from the early University period

Why not the Waystone Inn?
The frame era is tonally excellent but narrow. It has three characters and one location. It is a deeply constrained gameplay space, brilliant for depth but not for exploring a world. Better as a late addition than an MVP.

Why not Tarbean?
Tarbean is rich but dark, socially limited (the player character is a feral orphan with minimal social access), and has fewer confirmed specific locations than the University. Strong candidate for Phase 2, not MVP.

Why not the troupe?
The troupe era is emotionally powerful but its most significant event (the massacre) is a fixed canon catastrophe. Building the troupe era correctly requires not only building a specific environment but building it in a way that makes its destruction land properly. That's a Phase 3 undertaking.

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13. PHASE PLAN

Phase 1: Canon Bible and Lore Extraction

Objective: Build the authoritative lore database before any content is created.
Outputs:
- Complete Lore Register with all Tier 1–3 facts from the three books
- Timeline document: key events, what's true when
- Character documents for all major canon characters
- Location inventory: all confirmed locations, their eras, their descriptions from text
- Magic system document: sympathy rules, costs, known effects, confirmed limits
- Currency and economy document: confirmed prices, denominations
- Social structure document: University ranks, Edema Ruh customs, class dynamics, Tehlin church, nobility

Risks:
- Fanon contamination if using wikis as primary source rather than text
- Underestimating the scope of this phase

Mitigation: Budget generously for this phase. All subsequent work depends on it. Every entry must cite a specific text passage.

Dependencies: Access to all three published books in searchable form.

Definition of Done: Every major element in the game has a citation in the Lore Register. No uncited elements exist in any content document.

Phase 2: World Model and Schema
Objective: Define the complete technical and structural framework before content is written.
Outputs:
- Final data schema for all entity types (location, NPC, item, event, world state, player state)
- University campus map with all confirmed rooms, exits, and access rules
- Imre map (confirmed locations)
- NPC roster for University era with complete character documents
- Dialogue rule framework
- Magic system rules document (how sympathy is adjudicated, what failure looks like)
- Academic rank and tuition system specification

Risks: Over-engineering the schema before knowing what the system actually needs
Mitigation: Build schema iteratively. Start with minimum viable fields, expand as actual content needs reveal gaps.

Dependencies: Phase 1 complete.

Definition of Done: A developer (or this project's equivalent) can use the schema to build one complete test location with one complete test NPC without inventing anything.

Phase 3: MVP Location and Interaction Systems
Objective: Build the University era to a playable state with core mechanics functioning.
Outputs:
- All core University locations navigable and described
- Imre and Eolian accessible
- Movement, time passage, and basic inventory working
- Money and tuition system working
- Sympathy system in basic playable form
- 3–4 canon-fixed events scripted
- Tone review: does this feel like Rothfuss's world?

Risks:
- Rooms feel like isolated set pieces rather than a living campus
- Sympathy system becomes gamey under pressure
- Tone drifts toward generic fantasy

Mitigation: Build in clusters (entire Fishery, entire Archive) rather than one room at a time. Sympathy must always ask "what does this cost?" Run tone review with readers who know the books.

Dependencies: Phase 2 complete.

Definition of Done: A player can spend one full in-game day at the University, attend class, work in the Fishery, eat dinner at Anker's, cross to Imre, and return, with all practical consequences tracked correctly.

Phase 4: NPC and Dialogue Systems
Objective: Make canon NPCs feel genuinely themselves.
Outputs:
- Simmon, Wilem, Elodin, Kilvin, Ambrose, Denna each dialogue-enabled with correct voice
- Conversation system that rewards attention and penalises aggression/carelessness
- NPC knowledge states that update based on world events
- Relationship tracking working

Risks:
- NPCs become quest-givers in disguise
- Elodin becomes too explicable
- Denna becomes a romance reward

Mitigation: Each NPC has a "refusal list" — things they never do, never explain, never provide cleanly. Elodin must always leave more questions than answers. Denna must never be reliably available or consistently deciphered.

Dependencies: Phase 3 complete.

Definition of Done: A reader of the books can have a conversation with Simmon and believe it; a conversation with Elodin and feel appropriately uncertain.

Phase 5: Reputation and Consequence Layer
Objective: Make the world feel like it remembers what the player does.
Outputs:
- Reputation system fully wired: academic, social, Eolian, master relationships
- Consequence propagation: how actions affect later scenes
- World state updating correctly across time
- Debt and promise tracking

Risks:
- Consequences feel arbitrary or punitive rather than realistic
- Reputation updates are too slow (nothing seems to matter) or too fast (everything feels reactive and gamey)

Mitigation: Test each consequence by asking "would this realistically happen, at this speed, in this social environment?" Slow is usually more correct than fast.

Dependencies: Phase 4 complete.

Definition of Done: A player who antagonises Ambrose early feels the effects 20 turns later in ways that feel inevitable, not mechanical.

Phase 6: Expansion to More Eras and Regions
Objective: Build out Tarbean, frame era, and troupe era as distinct playable experiences.
Outputs:
- Tarbean with Skarpi, the Tehlin church, Dockside, Waterside, the Hillside districts
- Frame era: Waystone Inn fully realised with Bast, Chronicler, and the weight of the world
- Troupe era: the wagons, the roads, Arliden, Laurian, Abenthy, and the approach of the massacre

Risks:
- The massacre becomes exploitable or trivialised
- The frame era becomes too chatty and loses its weight
- Tarbean poverty becomes tourism rather than genuine hardship

Mitigation: Each era has its own tone document. The massacre is approached with the same care as a canon-fixed tragedy: the player cannot prevent it, only experience it. The frame era's dialogue is sparse and deliberate.

Dependencies: Phases 1–5 complete.

Definition of Done: A player can meaningfully inhabit each era for at least 2–3 hours of play with correct consequences and no canon drift.

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14. RISK ANALYSIS

Risk	Severity	Probability	Mitigation
Lore contradiction — game contradicts established canon	Critical	Medium	Lore Register with citations as foundation; canon audit at end of every phase
Scope explosion — too many eras, locations, characters attempted too soon	High	High	Strict scope definition; hard rule: nothing new until current phase is done
Bland prose — narration feels like generic fantasy text	High	Medium	Tone review with book-familiar readers; no narration written without Location Design Document
Weak NPC voices — characters feel like delivery systems	High	High	Character Voice Documents; refusal lists; separate review for each major NPC
Generic fantasy drift — magic becomes gamey, world loses texture	High	Medium	Regular "canon audit"; magic system has explicit "no" list; keep consequences physical and social
Broken timeline logic — facts bleed across eras, player has wrong knowledge	High	Low with discipline	Timeline model is separate per era; player state resets cleanly between eras; automated cross-era flag

Mystery resolved cheaply — Chandrian backstory explained, patron revealed	Critical	Low with discipline	Mystery register: all series mysteries listed with explicit "never resolve in game" flag
Over-modelling too soon — complex systems built before content proves they're needed	Medium	High	Schema-minimal start; expand only when actual content requires it
Auri handled incorrectly — made too explicable, too functional, too sane	High	Medium	Auri has her own separate canon document; all Auri content reviewed against SRST specifically
Felurian becomes shallow — reduced to seduction trope	High	Low (not in MVP)	Felurian is out of scope until Phase 6; when included, requires dedicated canon review
Frame era loses weight — Kote becomes too talkative, too helpful	High	Medium	Kote has a "silence quota" — minimum proportion of turns where he says little or nothing
Fanon contamination — Reddit theories treated as fact	Medium	Medium	All facts traced to text; wiki only as finding aid; no uncited claims

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15. TOOLING RECOMMENDATION

Option A: Pure Interactive Fiction Engine (Inform 7, Twine, Ink)

Pros: Well-established, designed for this genre, good branching dialogue support, portable.

Cons: Static content only — everything must be pre-written. Scaling to the density this project requires means thousands of nodes. Very hard to maintain tone quality at scale. Limited dynamic world state. Ink is the strongest candidate here (linear-friendly, state variables, good for prose), but still limited.

Verdict: Appropriate for a small, focused prototype (one location, one era). Will not scale to the full vision without serious pain.

Option B: Custom App with Structured Data

Pros: Full control over schema, state, and presentation. Can model the world exactly as designed. Scales well if structured properly.

Cons: Significant engineering work. All prose still pre-written. Maintaining thousands of dialogue trees and location descriptions is a large content burden.

Verdict: Good long-term architecture, especially with a React/TypeScript front end and a structured JSON or SQLite back end. Best for a developer-led project. The schema plan above maps well to this approach.

Option C: LLM-Assisted Dynamic Narration with Canon Database

Pros: Dramatically reduces pre-written content burden. Dynamic narration can handle variation (time of day, weather, player state) without pre-writing every variant. NPCs can converse more naturally. Tone can be adjusted via prompt engineering. The canon database provides hard constraint on what the LLM can say.

Cons: Requires very careful prompt architecture to prevent canon drift. LLM will occasionally hallucinate facts, require canon-checking layer. Consistency is harder to guarantee across sessions. Requires ongoing API cost.

Verdict: This is genuinely the most powerful approach if and only if the canon database is built first and the LLM is tightly constrained by it. The LLM handles prose variation and conversational naturalness; the database handles what is true. This is the most ambitious option but also the most scalable.

Option D: Hybrid — Structured Engine with LLM Narration Layer

Pros: The structured engine controls world state, movement, consequences, and canon facts. The LLM only writes narration and handles conversational texture, within strict boundaries. Best of both approaches.

Cons: More complex architecture. The boundary between "what the engine controls" and "what the LLM narrates" must be precisely defined and enforced.

Verdict: This is the recommended approach. The engine is the canon guardian. The LLM is the prose voice, not the lore source.

Recommended Stack (Conceptual)

```
Canon Database (JSON/SQLite)
   ↓
World State Engine (TypeScript/Python)
   ↓ controls ↓
What is true, what is available, what has changed
   ↓ passes context to ↓
LLM Narration Layer (constrained system prompt)
   ↓ generates ↓
Narration and dialogue in tone-correct prose
   ↓ returns to ↓
Player-facing interface (web or terminal)
```

The LLM's system prompt is essentially the first section of this document — the tone rules, the character rules, the mystery rules — plus the current world state and player state as structured data. The LLM cannot invent lore because the engine only passes it confirmed facts.

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16. FINAL RECOMMENDATION

Recommended Project Shape

A hybrid structured-engine / LLM narration system, canon-database-first, built in phases starting from the University era.

The project is not a game in the conventional sense. It is a canon-faithful interactive world where the primary experience is inhabiting the books' setting with consequence and texture. Think of it as somewhere between 80 Days and Pentiment in spirit — literary, consequence-driven, unhurried, specific.

Recommended MVP

University Era, early in Kvothe's time there. Single playable character (Kvothe). Five to seven core locations fully realised. Six NPCs with correct voice. Working sympathy, money, tuition, and reputation systems. Three to four canon-anchored events. One complete day of play feels like being in the books.

This MVP proves the concept, establishes the tone, tests the systems, and gives readers of the books something immediately recognisable and satisfying.

Recommended Order of Work

1. Build the Lore Register (canon bible) — 2–4 weeks of careful text work
2. Define the world schema — 1–2 weeks
3. Build University campus locations — 3–4 weeks
4. Build core NPC character documents and dialogue framework — 2–3 weeks
5. Implement core systems (movement, money, sympathy basics, reputation) — 4–6 weeks
6. Integrate LLM narration layer with canon constraints — 2–3 weeks
7. Playtest with book-familiar readers; identify tone drift; correct — ongoing
8. Expand to Imre and the Eolian — 2 weeks
9. Phase 2: Tarbean or frame era

The 10 Most Important Decisions You Need to Make Next

1. What is the technical platform? Pure interactive fiction engine, custom app, or hybrid LLM approach? This determines everything about how you build.

2. Will this be a solo project or collaborative? The content volume required for a faithful University era alone is substantial. Solo is achievable for MVP; full vision likely benefits from collaboration.

3. How do you handle magic adjudication? Will sympathy outcomes be pre-scripted, rule-driven by the engine, or dynamically assessed by the LLM against the rules? Each has different implications.

4. How tightly do you bind to Kvothe as the primary character? Playing only as Kvothe dramatically simplifies timeline logic. Playing as other characters adds enormous complexity. MVP should probably be Kvothe-only.

5. What does the player interface actually look like? Pure text parser, structured choice menus, or hybrid prose-with-suggested-actions? This affects how the world feels to navigate.

6. How will you handle the LLM's tendency to invent lore? This is your single biggest technical risk if you go the LLM route. Decide on your constraint architecture before writing a line of prompt.

7. Will you include canon-fixed events that the player cannot change? If yes, how do you handle player frustration when they cannot prevent the massacre or the whipping? The answer is in the texture of agency around those events — but you need a clear philosophy.

8. What is your tone review process? Who reads new content, what are they checking for, and who has authority to reject something as tonally wrong?

9. How do you handle the mysteries? Do you have a written rule that explicitly lists each unresolved series mystery and marks it "never resolve in-game"? This needs to be a formal constraint, not just an intention.

10. What is your canon source for Book 3 content? The Doors of Stone is unpublished. Some elements from later in Wise Man's Fear are less thoroughly described than early University content. Where is your line for "we don't have enough canon to build this yet"?

This document should be treated as a living planning artefact. Revisit the scope definition and risk register at the end of each phase. The canon bible is the foundation — do not shortcut it.